

CRUSHING BLOW
Officials destroy confiscated liquor in Ahmedabad

bition as this is the land of Mahatma Gandhi.

AAP has nothing to lose here; it is the BJP that is walking a tightrope as Gujarat is split wide open over the issue. The urban middle class and industry want prohibition gone, but the tribal and OBC communities—which form 18 and 52 per cent of the electorate, respectively—want it to continue. Urban areas make up 55 seats in Ahmedabad, Vadodara, Surat and Rajkot; the BJP won 44 of these in 2017.

After 27 years in power, the BJP can ill afford the apathy of its loyal urban middle and upper middle class voters. "The first murmurs about the lifting of prohibition started after Narendra Modi first came to power on a pro-industry plank in 2000. But in the initial years, Modi was consolidating his votebank and, for a variety of reasons, the move did not happen," says political analyst Gaurang Jani.

Industry sources confide that Modi, as CM, had promised many times at closed-door meetings that prohibition would be lifted soon, but the announcement never came. He did, however, relax the laws to allow group liquor permits for conferences and also set up a protocol for getting permits online. But the process remains cumbersome.

"The ideological aura of Gandhian institutions was powerful till about a decade ago, and they did not allow the move. Today, these institutions are weak. In fact, the BJP has taken over the Gandhian mantle, which is quite a departure," says Jani.

Dilip Thakkar, former secretary of the Hotel and Restaurant Owners' Association (HRA), says that in the past 45 years, representations have been made to every chief minister to at least relax the laws so that premium institutions could sell alcohol. "The hospitality industry estimates that the liquor restrictions result in a 30-50 per cent loss in business to Udaipur and Mount Abu in Rajasthan, Daman and Diu, and Maharashtra in outbound domestic tourism, corporate events and wedding celebrations," says Thakkar. Industry associations refuse to come on record, but say growth is stunted in sectors requiring skilled manpower as the attrition rate is very high.

IT'S A FRAUGHT ISSUE FOR THE BJP. GUJARAT IS SPLIT WIDE OPEN ON IT: A DRY STATE MEANS LOSSES FOR INDUSTRY, BUT THE VAST TRIBAL/ OBC SEGMENT WANTS IT

On the other side, there are people like OBC leader Alpesh Thakor (currently a claimant for the BJP ticket from Radhanpur constituency in north Gujarat) who formed his Thakor Sena and shot to prominence primarily on the issue of alcohol abuse among the OBC communities. "The issues of the urban classes and industry are secondary...alcoholism is a real problem in the lower middle class and backward communities. Any party that talks of removing prohibition will be looking at losing at least 20 per cent of the female vote in rural Gujarat," he says.

The BJP is also making a big play for the tribal vote, which was earlier a loyal Congress votebank but is now increasingly fragmented. Jani concedes that safety and decorum in public places in Gujarat—largely attributed to prohibition—is a huge plus for the government.

Ex-CM Shankersinh Vaghela, who now heads the Praja Shakti Democratic Party (PSDP), recently reiterated his stand that prohibition has to go. "It's a fake law riddled with corruption. Liquor flows in Gujarat thanks to the bootlegger-police nexus, but it is the tribals and poor who bear the brunt as they have to make do with spurious hooch since their healthy organic liquor from the local *mahudo* tree is also banned."

In 2018, then CM Vijay Rupani sought a special compensation package from the 15th Finance Commission citing a prohibition-induced loss of Rs 9,864 crore in excise duty. AAP pegs the loss at Rs 15,000 crore annually. PSDP spokesperson Parthesh Patel points to a two-year survey that suggests the police-politician-bootlegger nexus mints about Rs 15,000 crore annually. "If implemented effectively, liquor sales tax and the industries it will benefit could bring in Rs 40,000 crore revenue in a financial year; the jobs created will be another plus," he says. It's always been a fraught issue, but perhaps it's time to open the topic up for debate. ■